IRB for Leaders: Protect the Value of Your Data

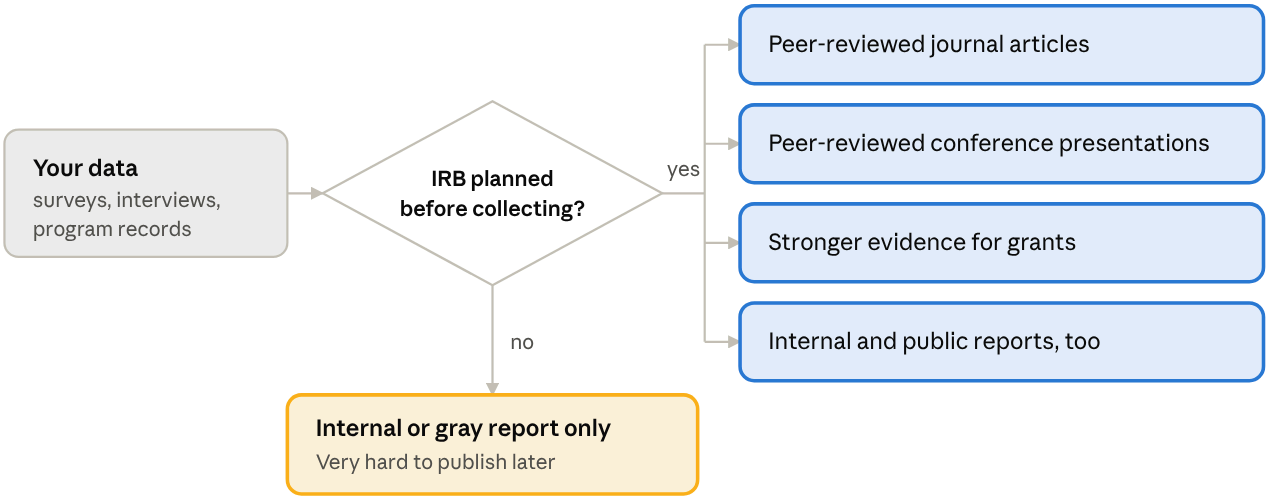
A five-minute guide for leaders who are not researchers.

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Your organization already collects valuable data: surveys, interviews, program records, feedback. Planning for IRB before you collect it decides whether that data can only stay in an internal report, or whether it can also become publications, conference presentations, and evidence for future funding.

The same data opens more doors when IRB comes first

The decision is made before anyone fills out a survey or sits for an interview



Same data, two paths · 1 decision

The survey, the interviews, and the work are the same either way. Only the planning is different.

What Is an IRB, in One Sentence?

An Institutional Review Board (IRB) is the office that reviews projects involving people to make sure they are ethical and protect participants' privacy. Most universities have one.

Why Leaders Should Care

Without IRB planning	With IRB planning
Findings stay in internal or gray reports	Findings can also be published in peer-reviewed journals
Cannot present at peer-reviewed research conferences	Can present at research conferences
Weaker evidence for grant proposals	Stronger evidence for grants and partnerships
Data is hard to reuse later	Data can support future studies and reports
Less visibility for the organization	More visibility and credibility for the organization's work

The key point: IRB approval is decided before data is collected. Once the data exists, it is very hard to publish it as research.

A Real Lesson

An organization surveyed and interviewed managers and HR staff about an important workforce issue. The findings were strong, but no one planned for IRB before collecting the data. The work could only become a gray report, not a peer-reviewed article or conference presentation. The same effort, with a few weeks of planning, could have produced both.

The One Question to Ask

Before any survey, interview, or evaluation begins, ask your team:

> **"Is there any chance we will want to publish or present this?"**

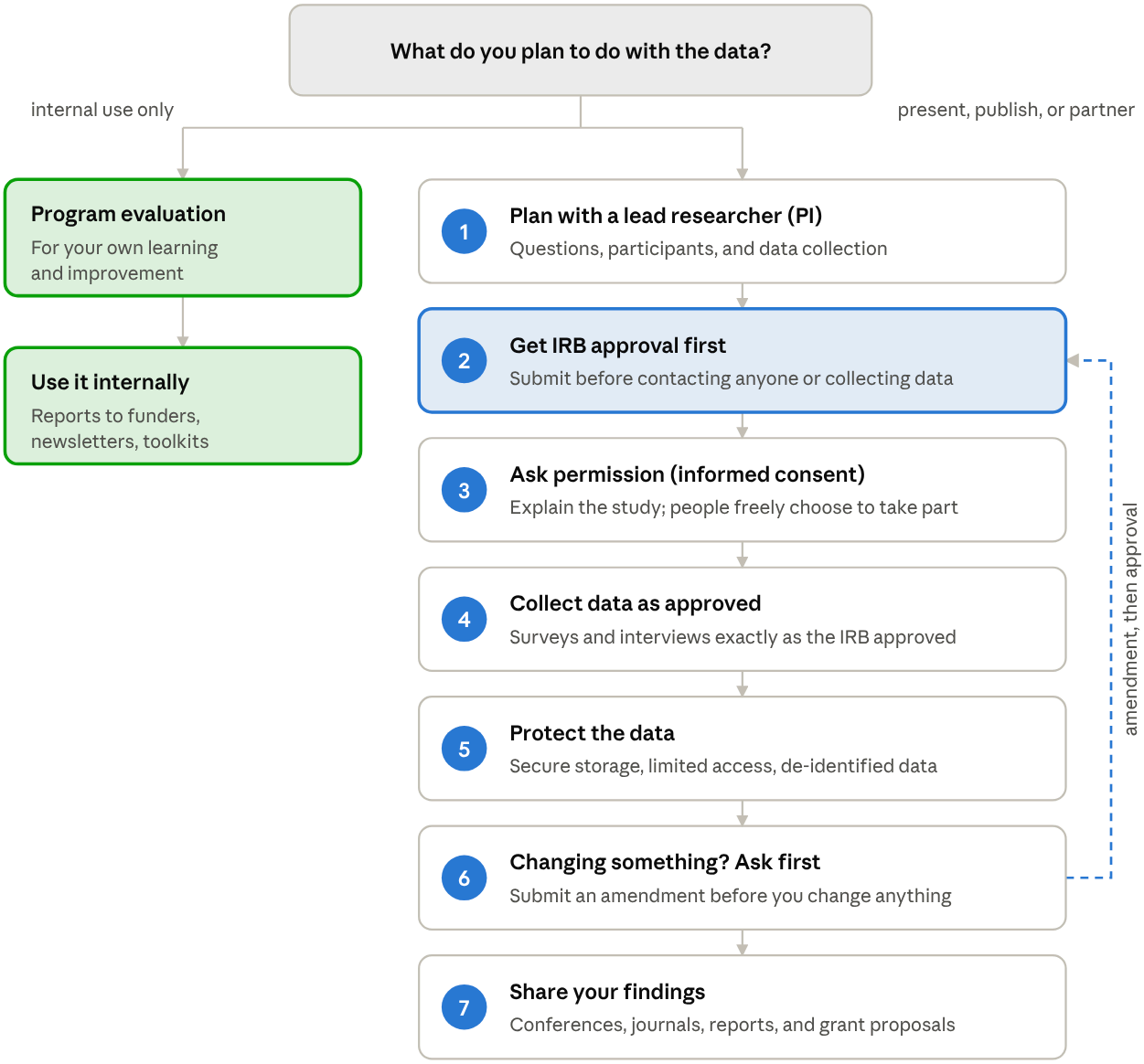
- **Yes or maybe:** Contact the IRB office before collecting data.
- **No, internal use only:** IRB review is likely not needed, but the findings stay internal.

The Research Roadmap

If you plan to present, publish, or partner with researchers, every step below happens in this order. If anything changes along the way, such as a new survey question or a new group of participants, the IRB must approve the change before you make it.

Research with people follows seven steps, and IRB comes before any data

A roadmap for leaders planning to share their work or partner with researchers



The research roadmap · 7 steps, 1 amendment loop

Protecting Participants and Their Data

Trust is the foundation of research with people. How you ask permission, where you store data, and which tools you use all matter, and the IRB will ask about each one.

Area	What to think about before you start
Permission	Explain the study in plain language. People must choose freely, can say no, and can stop at any time.
What you collect	Collect only what you need. Avoid names and identifying details unless they are truly necessary.
Where you store it	Use storage your institution approves, with encryption and password protection. Avoid personal laptops, personal email, and personal cloud accounts.
Third-party tools	Survey platforms, video calls, transcription services, and AI tools may store or process data on outside servers. Check that each tool is approved before you use it.
Who can access it	Limit access to the approved research team only.
De-identifying	Replace names with codes, and keep the key that links codes to names separate and secure.
Sharing results	Report findings so no individual can be recognized, especially in small groups.
Keeping and deleting	Follow your IRB's rules for how long to keep data and how to delete it safely.

Remember: A data breach or a broken promise to participants can damage your organization's reputation far more than any delay from planning ahead.

What It Takes

- A short project description: who you will survey or interview, what you will ask, and how you will protect their privacy
- A review period, which varies by institution and type of review, so plan ahead

- A responsible researcher, called the Principal Investigator (PI), who leads the study and is accountable to the IRB. The PI usually must complete human subjects training, and many institutions require the PI to be faculty or approved staff, so check your IRB's rules. If your team has no researcher, bring one in at the planning stage, before you design a survey or collect any data. A researcher cannot rescue data that was collected without IRB approval.

It is a small investment of time compared with the value of the data.

Questions to Ask Your Team

- What data are we collecting now, or planning to collect?
- Could any of it become a publication, presentation, or grant evidence?
- Can anyone be identified from the data?
- Who on our team can work with the IRB office?

Let's Work Together

Good research is a partnership. Leaders bring the programs, the community relationships, and the real-world questions. Researchers bring the methods, the ethics, and the IRB process. When we plan together from the start, we protect participants, strengthen your organization, and turn your work into lessons others can learn from. If you are planning a survey, interviews, or an evaluation, let's talk before you begin.

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How This Guide Was Made

This guide is based on my experience helping organizations turn program work into research. I used Claude (by Anthropic) as a thinking partner to brainstorm ideas and help design the visuals. All decisions were my own.

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